

EXCLUSIVE

IAS PRELIMS 2026

CURRENT AFFAIRS

REVISION

GS-1 (DYNAMIC)

MODULE - 67



**INTERNATIONAL
EVENTS - 4**



WHY IS ARTICLE 5 OF THE NATO IN THE NEWS?

- US feels that the stand of European countries violates Article 5 of the NATO, which states that “an armed attack against one NATO member shall be considered an attack against them all”.
- However, NATO allies refused US requests for military and airspace support in connection with the war against Iran.
- While Spain and Italy have directly criticized the US-Israeli strikes on Iran, France has denied US military jets overflight permission to fly to Israel.
- Even the US's closest allies - the UK, Germany and Canada - have refused to take part in operations.

WHAT DO YOU KNOW ABOUT NATO?



- NATO or OTAN (according to the French abbreviation) was formed in 1949 with the US, Canada and 10 West European countries, which felt threatened by the Soviet Union, particularly after the installation of pro-Soviet communist regimes in Eastern Europe and China.
- It was signed in Washington DC on April 4, 1949. It created the intergovernmental military grouping mandated with collective security.
- Over time, NATO gathered more members, including Greece and Turkey in the 1950s and Spain in 1982. The total membership at present is 32.
- It did not carry out a single military operation during the Cold War. However, the NATO forces began joint operational missions since 1990s, such as in Iraq (1990 and 2003), Bosnia (1992), Kosovo (1999), and Afghanistan (2001).

NATO DOES NOT HAVE A SEPARATE INDEPENDENT FORCE!



- NATO does not have a separate independent force, but when required combines resources and personnel of the 32 members that operate under a unified command structure called the SHAPE (Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe), based in Belgium.
- It is led by the Supreme Allied Commander Europe, a US four-star general or admiral who heads the US European Command.

WHAT IS THE ROLE OF NATO IN UKRAINE?

- Although Ukraine has now backed away from plans to join NATO, Ukrainian forces have worked closely with NATO after Russia launched its special military operations in February 2022.
- Ukraine has received major aid packages, including a \$40 billion pledge at the NATO summit in 2024, training and security assistance.



WHAT ABOUT THE FUNDING FOR NATO?

- The US has provided much of NATO's funding, including 62% of the defence spending and about 15% of the civil budget of the alliance.
- It also provides NATO countries with a nuclear umbrella and maintains US military bases that enhance deterrence in the region.
- Under increasing security concerns and US pressure, all NATO members agreed at the 2025, Hague Summit to raise defence spending to 5% of their GDP by 2035.

CAN US PULL OUT OF THE NATO?



- It is much more legally complex than the UK's exit from the European Union (Brexit) in January 2020.
- Article 13 provides for the withdrawal of any member but says the member must submit a one-year notice of denunciation to the government of the USA, which will inform the governments of other parties.
- As the depository authority, the US government would therefore have to hand itself the notice and then inform other countries, which would make for an awkward process.
- The Biden administration pushed a law through the US Congress in 2023, that prohibits the US President from trying to suspend, terminate, denounce or withdraw the USA from NATO - without the advice and consent of the Senate or an act of Congress. However, alternative paths could see the US withdraw personnel from SHAPE or skip NATO meetings.



DEEP DIVISIONS IN 14th MINISTERIAL CONFERENCE OF WTO

- The 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14) of the World Trade Organization (WTO) in Yaounde, Cameroon ended without agreement underlining deeper structural problems that endanger the future of multilateralism. This concerns the organization's relevance at a time when the rules of the game in global trade have been entirely upended.



VARIOUS ASPECTS THAT CAME TO THE FOREFRONT IN THE CONTEXT OF MC14 AT YAOUNDE, CAMEROON



- Ministerial Conference is the WTO's highest decision-making body and generally meets once every two years.
- The Most Favoured Nation (MFN) epitomizes non-discrimination and the obligation not to impose tariffs beyond bound rates.
- Appellate body - the organization's highest judicial arm is dysfunctional due to blocking the appointment of members by USA.
- Over the past two-three decades, the WTO has created only two new agreements - the Trade Facilitation Agreement and the Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies. This is because of consensus-based decision making.
- WTO allows plurilateral trade agreements - agreements between fewer than all WTO members. These are typically included in Annex IV of the WTO Treaty. These agreements bind only the signatories. However, for inclusion in Annex IV, such agreements must be approved by consensus among all WTO members.
- WTO's e-commerce moratorium was first approved in 1998 and renewed every two years. This agreement facilitates no import tariffs on electronic transmissions. The moratorium expired on March 31, 2026. Given the rise in digital trade, continuing the moratorium could lead to significant revenue losses for developing countries.
- There is also a provision of Special and Differential Treatment (SDT) for Developing and Least Developed Countries (LDCs).



- It is the dollar dominated system that underpins global oil trade and gives Washington significant financial leverage.
- Since the 1970s, most crude oil - regardless of where it is produced or consumed - has been priced and settled in US dollars. This forces oil-importing countries to hold dollar reserves to secure energy supplies creating global demand for the currency.
- Oil-exporting nations, in turn, receive large dollar inflows that are often recycled into US government bonds and financial markets, reinforcing demand for US debt and helping sustain the dollar's state as the world's dominant reserve currency.
- The dollar-based oil system lowers US borrowing costs, supports large government spending, and strengthens the effectiveness of financial tools such as sanctions and asset freezes.

Challenges to the petrodollar are often seen as strategic threats rather than routine commercial decisions.



AYATOLLAH ALI KHAMENEI KILLED

- Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, was killed in a joint US-Israel strike. This marks a dramatic escalation in the widening conflict between Iran and the United States and Israel.
- As per USA, the operation that killed Khamenei was a coordinated US-Israel air and naval strike dubbed "The Epic Fury". It was reportedly timed to coincide with a high-level meeting of Iran's top leadership.



A BRIEF ON IRAN



- Iran, officially the Islamic Republic of Iran, is also known as Persia. Its population is over 92 million. Tehran is the nation's capital.
- The government is unitary presidential theocratic Islamic Republic under an authoritarian dictatorship.
- The supreme leader is the de-facto head of state and the highest political and religious authority of Iran (above the President). The armed forces, judiciary, state radio and television, and other key government organizations are subject to the supreme leader.
- Currency is Iranian Rial. Nominal GDP is around 356 billion dollars and Per capita GDP is around 4,000 dollars.
- HDI is high at 0.799. Twelver Jafari Shia Islam is the official state religion. The Constitution of 1979 recognizes Sunni Muslims, Christians, Jews, and Zoroastrians. However, Baha'i faith is persecuted and unrecognized.

A BRIEF ON AYATOLLAH ALI KHAMENEI



- Ali Hosseini Khamenei was born on April 19, 1939 in Mashhad into a clerical family. He studied Islamic theology in Mashhad and later in Qom. He came under the influence of revolutionary cleric Ruhollah Khomeini, the architect of the 1979 Islamic Revolution.
- In 1981, during the Iran-Iraq War, led by Saddam Hussein, Khamenei was elected President of Iran.
- Following the death of Ayatollah Khomeini in 1989, Iran's Assembly of Experts appointed Khamenei as Supreme Leader.
- In 2015, Iran reached a nuclear deal with world powers under President Rouhani. However, President Trump withdrew the United States from the agreement in 2018 and reimposed sanctions, deepening tensions.

Under sustained sanctions, Khamenei promoted a resistance economy aimed at reducing dependence on western markets.

WHY DID THE US AND ISRAEL ATTACK IRAN?

Iranian senior leadership and defence figures



Ayatollah Ali Khamenei
Supreme leader



Ali Larijani
Secretary of Supreme
National Security
Council



Ali Shamkhani
Head of National
Defence Council



Masoud Pezeshkian
President



Mohammad Pakpour
Commander in chief
of IRGC



Aziz Nasirzadeh
Defence minister

- Israel and the US - its closest ally - have been arch foes of Iran since the Islamic Revolution in 1979. The Iranian leadership has consistently called for Israel's elimination and denounced the US as its greatest enemy.
- The two countries have led Western opposition to Iran's nuclear program, claiming Iran is seeking to develop a nuclear bomb, something Iran has vehemently denied. They attacked Iranian nuclear and military sites in June 2025. Since then, they have claimed Iran has been trying to rebuild its nuclear program and develop missiles capable of delivering nuclear weapons.
- Hence, Israel considers Iran a threat to its existence and wants the complete removal of Iran's nuclear and missile program as well as a regime change.

Location

Iran is a large country in the **Middle East** between Iraq and Afghanistan.

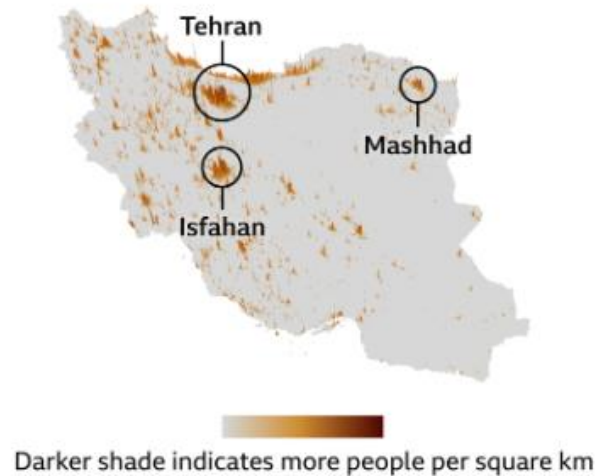
It was home to an ancient civilisation and was known to the outside world as **Persia** until it became Iran in 1935.



Population

It has a population of over **90 million** people - making it one of the biggest countries in the Middle East.

Most people live in the north, where the capital **Tehran** is, and in the west.

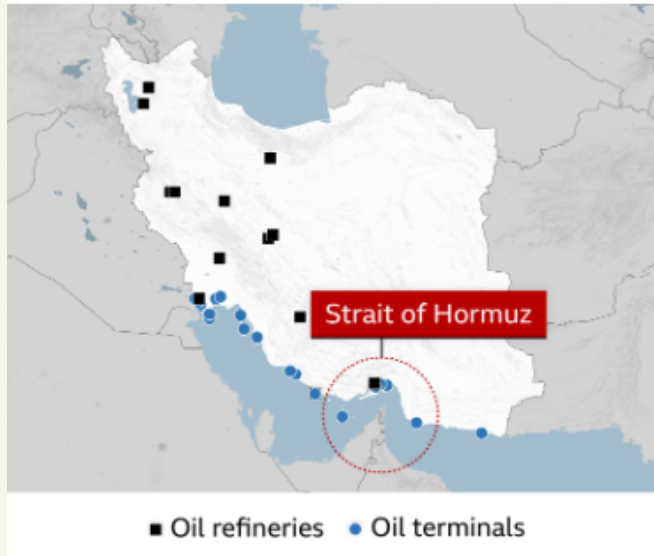


IMPORTANT ASPECTS IN THE CONTEXT OF ATTACK ON IRAN

Economy

Iran's growth has stagnated after years of sanctions and mismanagement.

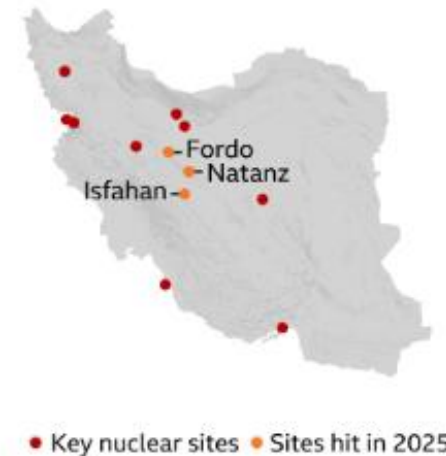
This is despite the country's **huge oil and gas reserves**, which it exports by sea through the key **Strait of Hormuz**.



Nuclear facilities

Iran insists its **nuclear programme** is entirely peaceful and denies that it is seeking to develop nuclear weapons.

The US and Israel bombed several of Iran's **key nuclear sites** in June 2025.



IMPORTANT ASPECTS IN THE CONTEXT OF ATTACK ON IRAN

• In Iran's growing stockpile of missiles



Iran also has a variety of military UAVs — including surveillance, and precision strikes and has reportedly acquired Soviet-era Kh-55 cruise missiles from Ukraine, with a range of up to 3,000 km



NOTE: MINIMUM RANGE ESTIMATES FOR SOME OF IRAN'S MISSILES ARE SHOWN.
SOURCE: CSIS MISSILE DEFENSE PROJECT, THE NEW YORK TIMES

IMPORTANT ASPECTS IN THE CONTEXT OF ATTACK ON IRAN

Chart 2: Top 10 producers of crude oil worldwide (1,000 barrels per day)

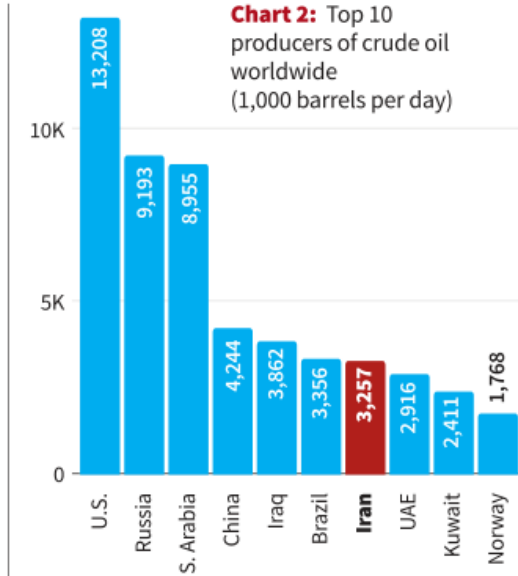


Chart 3: Volume of crude oil and petroleum transported through the Strait of Hormuz by select countries of origin

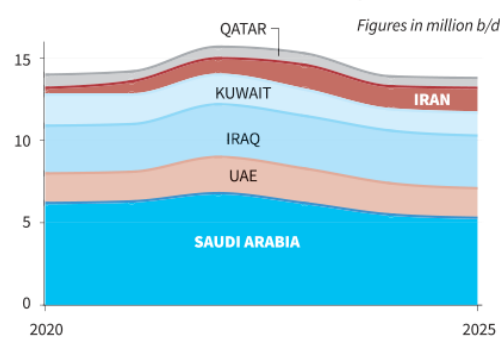


Chart 4: Volume of crude oil transported through the Strait of Hormuz by destination

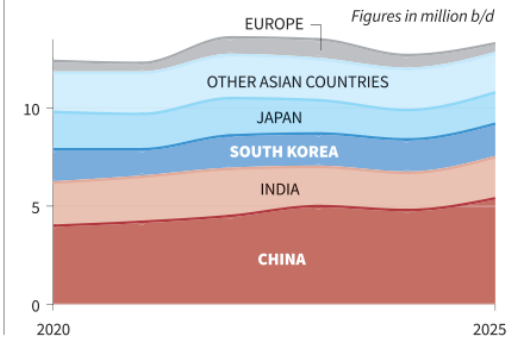
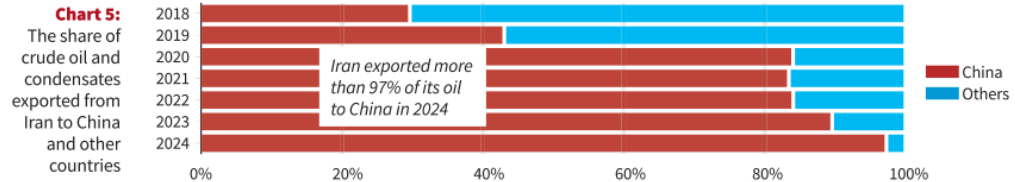
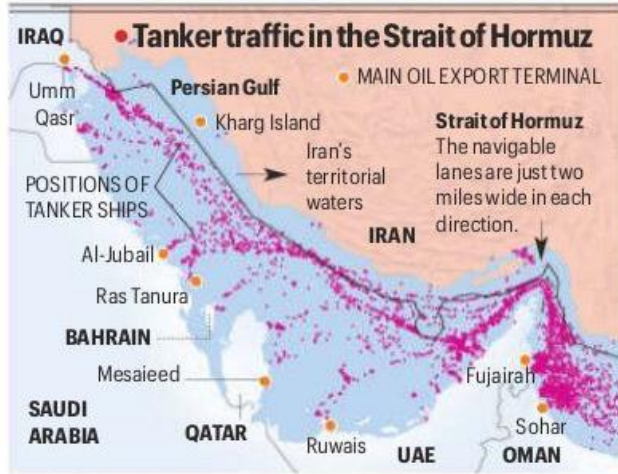


Chart 5: The share of crude oil and condensates exported from Iran to China and other countries



IMPORTANT ASPECTS IN THE CONTEXT OF ATTACK ON IRAN



NOTE: SHOWS DAILY TANKER POSITIONS FROM FEB 1 TO FEB 15.
SOURCES: THE NEW YORK TIMES; KPLER, MARINE REGIONS, FLANDERS MARINE INSTITUTE.

• Indians in the war zone

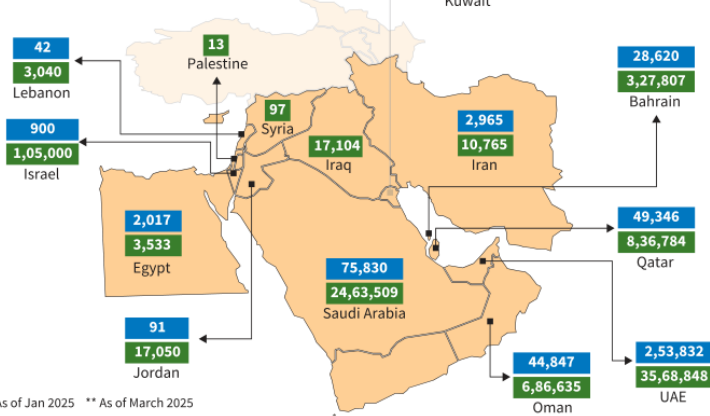
Country	NRI	PIO	Total
Bahrain	3.23 lakh	3,899	3.27 lakh
Saudi Arabia	24.60 lakh	2,906	24.63 lakh
Qatar	8.35 lakh	1,609	8.36 lakh
UAE	35.54 lakh	14,574	35.68 lakh
Kuwait	9.93 lakh	2,244	9.95 lakh
Oman	6.84 lakh	1,864	6.86 lakh
Iran	10,320	445	10,765
Israel	20,000	85,000	1.05 lakh

SOURCE: POPULATION OF OVERSEAS INDIANS, MINISTRY OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS

IMPORTANT ASPECTS IN THE CONTEXT OF ATTACK ON IRAN

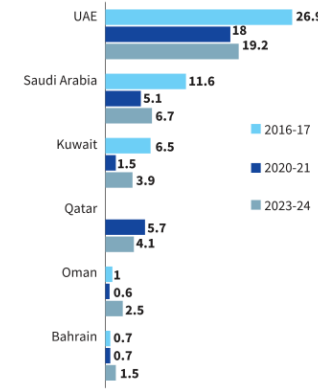
Over 90 lakh Indians live in countries caught in geopolitical tensions

■ Indian students* ■ Total Indians**



Remittances from West Asia have declined in the last decade

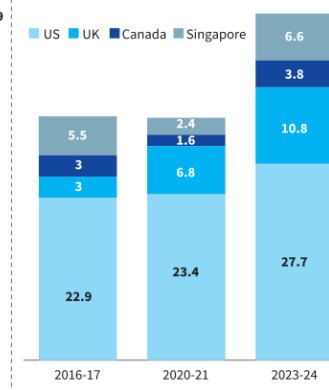
Country-wise share of remittances over the years (%)



Source: MEA, RBI

Skilled migration has brought in more remittances from US, UK and others

Country-wise share of remittances over the years (%)



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